The Eastern Front

Bengal had already faced a short-lived partition in 1905, supposedly on administrative grounds, but that measure did not trigger major population movements. The Partition of Bengal in 1947, however, was a different matter altogether. Compared to the western frontier, which witnessed larger displacements and casualties, the displacement along the eastern frontier was more unbalanced and prolonged. By 1951, India had sent 7,00,000 migrants across the new eastern border and received 2.5 million migrants, mainly in West Bengal and parts of present-day Assam and Tripura.[31] India later received close to 2 million more migrants in the 1950s and ’60s with virtually no flow in the reverse direction.[32] Casualties along the eastern front are difficult to estimate because the Bengal Famine of 1943 had already taken a huge toll, but recent research is converging on an estimate of around one million people, in contrast with a figure of over two million along the western front.[33] A breakup of casualties in terms of those killed by violence as opposed to disease, exhaustion and other factors is not available, but the casualty to displacement ratio appears to be much higher along the eastern front than in the west. Serious riots in several districts, especially Noakhali and Tippera in Chittagong division of East Bengal, had broken out in late 1946, moving thousands of people, mostly Hindus, into shelter camps well before Independence.[34] The madness continued in eastern India, and on the eve of Independence, Gandhi was praying for peace in Calcutta, far away from all the political action in Delhi. Post-Partition, the violence continued sporadically until major riots broke out again in early 1950, prompting more inflows of Hindus from East Bengal into India. Migration from East Bengal was therefore a more ‘fluid’ problem for policymakers, ‘the pace being determined from time to time by political events in Pakistan’.[35] Many did not migrate to India in the initial years, echoing perhaps the views of the old man in the novel *The Shadow Lines:*[36]